

Online Data Collection

In the current climate some of you might struggle with your primary data collection. Here a few tips about how you may be able to overcome difficulties of meeting people to gather information, and at the same time stay safe, by using online methods of data gathering. Of course, this will only work if the people you want to include in your research have internet access.

For **qualitative** data collection –

- Tape recording:
 - o with your phone
 - o get a digital recorder from an online shop - they are not that expensive anymore and pretty good
 - o software such as Microsoft Teams has a recording function: just make sure to practise using it before the first interview (https://tel.yorks.ac.uk/microsoft-teams-for-teaching/#collapse_vunkyp).
- Conduct the interview/focus group:
 - o Via Microsoft Teams – you got free access to Microsoft Teams through your YSJ account <https://tel.yorks.ac.uk/microsoft-teams-for-teaching/>
 - o Via Zoom – freely accessible but has some time limitations
 - o Via Skype – for free but the quality tends to be weaker than Microsoft team
 - o Via Facetime – if you and they have Apple equipment

From our experience it is actually quite easy to collect interview data via one of these tools. With the software from Microsoft Teams you can record interviews easily (so no issues around batteries running low - except on your laptop/phone, so make sure to have your device fully charged).

For focus groups, it might be a bit trickier, especially when the group gets bigger than four: in Microsoft Teams you might then not be able to see every participant. The other issues with focus groups occurs when more than one person starts talking: however, it could also make it easier for you to insist that only one person speaks at a time, to stop people from talking over one another. Do a pilot test with whatever tool you are planning to use so you are familiar with it.

Whatever tool you use, ensure that your participants are comfortable using it and put a short guide together for how to use it. They are doing you a favour by taking part in your research, and if this becomes difficult for them they might choose not to take part.

Finally, with interviews and focus groups make sure that people are aware that you are recording the session and that they consent to this.

For **quantitative** Data collection –

- An online survey development tool - Qualtrics – is freely accessible through YSJ <https://www.yorks.ac.uk/students/digital-resources/digital-training/other-programs-help/qualtrics-help/>

This is a simple and quick way to gather data, and the tool will also help you to analyse the returns.